

Denver's homelessness response

What \$178 million bought, and four ways to spend it better — from public data.

All In Mile High moved 3,902 people indoors between July 2023 and June 2025.
Three numbers explain why it cost so much — and how to bring the cost down.

\$105,074

per person who reached permanent housing

Auditor-estimated \$178.1M ÷ ~1,695 exits
HMIS via Denver Auditor, March 2026

\$34–36k /yr

paid per shelter bed per year

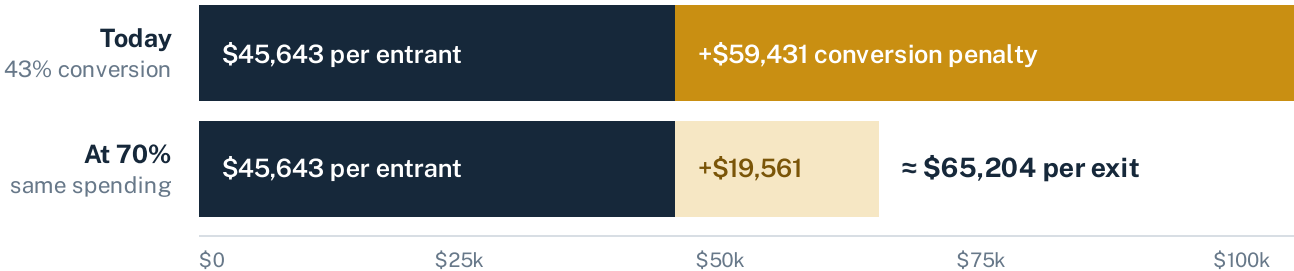
HOST 2026 budget: Aspen \$93.77/night, Stone Creek \$98.60/night — about the price of permanent supportive housing

43%

of entrants exited to long-term housing

~13% of that “housing” was HUD-classified temporary; returns are never subtracted

Why one exit costs \$105,074

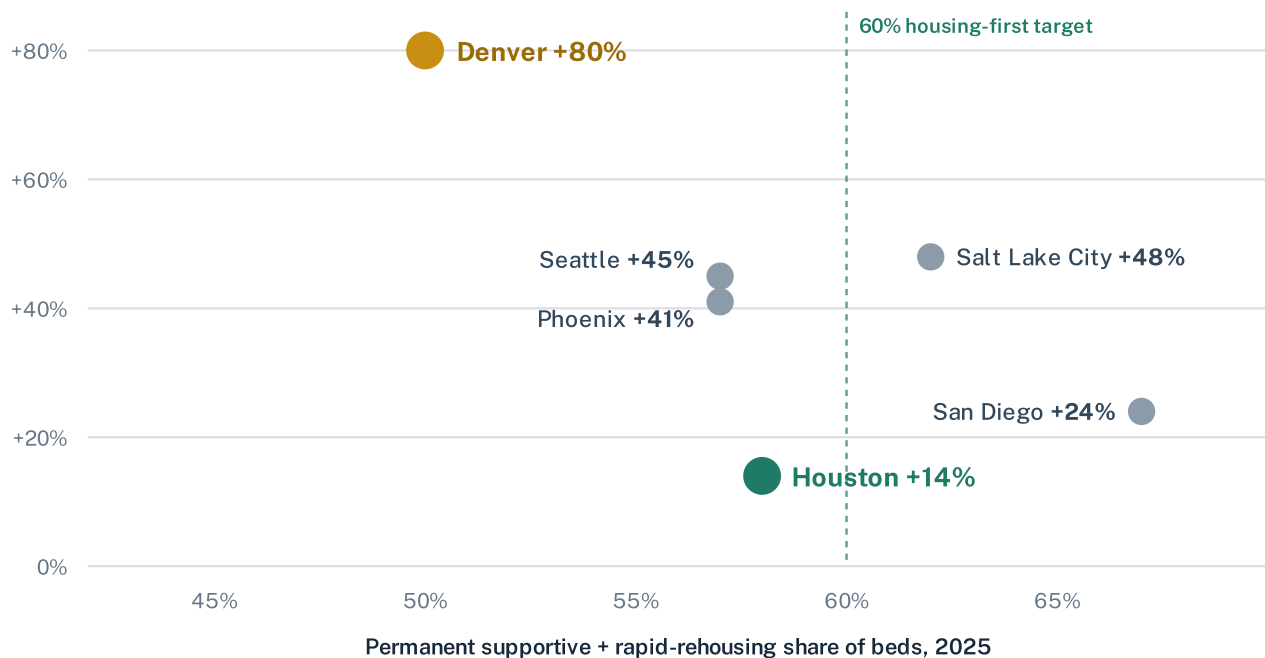


More than half the headline is the arithmetic penalty of a 43% conversion rate — not the cost of helping someone. Raise conversion to 70% and the cost falls to ~\$65k with zero new spend.

It's the bed mix, not the bed count

Six western continuums of care, HUD data 2019–2025. Cities that held most beds as permanent supportive housing + rapid rehousing kept homelessness flatter. Denver nearly doubled shelter beds — and rose the fastest.

Change in homelessness rate per 10,000 residents, 2019–2025



Read it one way

Denver +80%. Houston +14%.

Denver went from 17.8 to 32.1 per 10k — the steepest rise of the six, while shelter beds nearly doubled. Houston went from 4.7 to 5.3 per 10k, holding ~60% housing-first beds for six years.

Read it another way

A shelter bed costs what a permanent one does.

Denver's shelter beds cost \$34–36k/yr to operate (HOST 2026 budget) — the same as Denver PSH (\$22–36k/person/yr, Urban Institute). Shifting a bed from hotel-shelter to PSH is roughly cost-neutral and converts a temporary bed into a permanent one.

Six-continuum correlation, not causal proof — labeled as such in the full analysis. Denver's 2024 PIT spike partly reflects expanded count methodology.

Sources: HUD Point-in-Time counts and Housing Inventory Counts by CoC, 2019–2025; HOST 2026 budget presentation (bed-night costs); Urban Institute Housing to Health evaluation (PSH costs).

Four ways to spend it better

Roughly costed, with the evidence behind each. Uncertainty is labeled — none of this is causal proof, all of it beats the status quo on paper.

1 Rebalance beds toward housing-first

Hold 60%+ of beds as PSH + rapid rehousing (Houston's level; Denver is at 50%).

Cost

Budget-neutral — reallocate within the
~\$89M/yr run-rate

Effect

~\$18M/yr shifted funds ~690 PSH slots at Denver PSH
costs

2 Fix outcome tracking

Per-shelter cost tracking; decrement counts on return; publish 1-year retention.

Cost

<\$1M one-time admin

Effect

Precondition for everything — you can't manage what
you don't measure

3 Target hotspot deployment

Concentrate placements in the 25 grid cells holding 24% of encampment reports.

Cost

~\$13M/yr for 500 placements

Effect

Placements, not sweeps, break the reappearance
cycle (+9pp at 150m/14d)

4 Unclog the shelter-to-housing funnel

Scale rapid rehousing + 12-month retention support; relieve 205-day stays.

Cost

\$10–15M for 1,000 households

Effect

43% → 70% conversion cuts cost per exit to ~\$65k
with zero new spend

What this doesn't prove

An honest accounting of the limits — so the numbers above carry weight.

- Point-in-Time counts are one-night snapshots and undercount; 2021 is methodologically broken.
- Denver's 2024 PIT spike partly reflects expanded count methodology, not pure growth.
- 311 volume reflects reporting behavior as well as ground truth (one day in March 2023 saw 1,116 app reports).
- Cross-city comparison is six continuums — correlation, not causal proof.
- Per-exit is one-time; PSH is annual — multi-year PSH stays cost more than one year.
- Inflow is unmeasured: formal evictions plausibly drive 5–20% of entries; the rest is estimated.
- Per-shelter cost splits remain unmeasurable from public data — the auditor's core complaint.

Sources

1. Denver Auditor, All In Mile High audit (March 2026) and City Shelters audit + follow-ups (2024–2026).
2. Denver Open Data Catalog: 382,746 NIBRS crime records (2021–2026); 74,113 311 encampment requests (2022–2025).
3. HUD Point-in-Time counts & Housing Inventory Counts by CoC, 2019–2025.
4. HOST 2026 budget presentation to City Council (bed-night costs); 2025 Scorecard (exits).
5. Urban Institute, Denver Housing to Health evaluation (PSH operating costs).
6. At Home/Chez Soi RCT; HUD-VASH; Evans et al. (Chicago prevention, *Science* 2016).

**Open data, open code.
Check our work.**

Full analysis, charts, and code will be published publicly. Every number above is cited.